

A HOUSE OF **MEMORIES**

The heritage Diwans Bungalow in Ahmedabad oozes history and character in equal measure

By AMIT DIXIT

The veteran architect I.M. Kadri, now in his 90s—who has designed iconic projects like the Nehru Centre in Mumbai and the Taj Mahal and Taj Palace hotels in Delhi—has fond memories of growing up in Diwans Bungalow, his ancestral home in Saiyad Wadu in Ahmedabad's Old CIty. The charming bungalow, painted in resplendent white, marries traditional Indian architecture with colonial elements, and was built in 1875 by his great-grandfather Sayad Bavamiyan Kadri, the Diwan of the princely state of Radhanpur.

The most striking feature of the stately home are two exquisitely carved wooden oriel windows which overlook the busy street in front. Lined with plush cushions, you can spend all day lounging here and watch the world go by. Inside is an island of calm, punctuated with fine jaalis, sharp arches and meticulous stucco work. The original stained glass has been carefully preserved. The central wing, Kadri recalls, was built in 1936 to accommodate a growing family and was designed by British architect Claude Batley.

Vintage family photographs adorn the walls, with bedrooms named after various family members. The centrepiece of the dining room is a chandelier from Belgium, once lit with candles. Behind the well-appointed